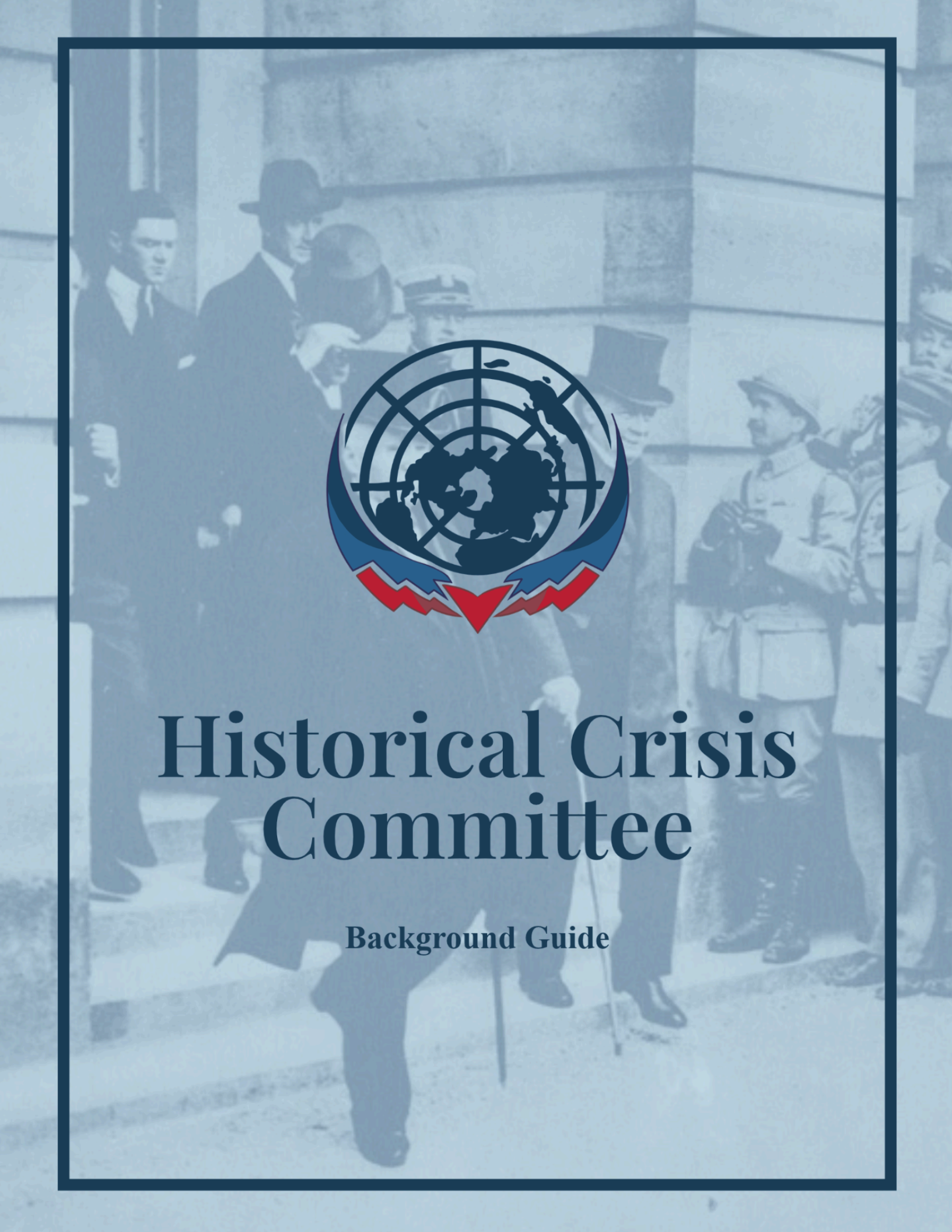


Historical Crisis Committee

Background Guide

Table of Contents

Director's Letter..... 2

Topic Overview..... 3

Bloc Positions..... 4

Guiding Questions..... 5

Works Cited..... 6

Director's Letter

Distinguished gentlemen and gentlewomen,

As you are aware, the world is at a crossroads. Great carnage and death has followed after the Great War, ripping apart the European and international world order as we know it. We must be ready to make difficult decisions to affirm the sacrifices of our countrymen. Despite the tremendous sacrifice, hostilities between the Entente and Central powers perpetuate onwards whilst you all must confront questions concerning the future of your respective nations. It is therefore imperative that we not only ensure the means by which this conflict ends, but also the terms to which a just and lasting peace may be secured.

With this in mind, it is my distinct honour to welcome you to the Historical Crisis Committee at Semiahmoo MUN 2026! My name is Sarah Wang and I will be your committee director alongside Jasmine Li, your chair. We eagerly await the opportunity to witness the diplomacy and political acumen that each of you will bring to the table. The challenges before us are immense, and inevitable disagreements will rise among you. Nevertheless, we entrust you with the responsibility of representing your respective governments, and protecting the future of a world grievously marred by war. We respectfully await your arrival.

May we all prevail against the evils of war.

Sarah Wang
Director of the Historical Crisis Committee

Topic Overview

"The fortunes of mankind are now in the hands of the plain people of the whole world."
~ Woodrow Wilson, Address to the Peace Conference in Paris, 25 January 1919

On June 28, 1914, Gavrilo Princip, a Bosnian-Serb student fired the two shots that were heard around the world. The man he killed— Archduke Franz Ferdinand— was heir to the Austro-Hungarian throne. This incident became the spark that fanned the flames of war. Twenty million lives lost to bring one to justice. However, the origins of the first modern war were set in motion long before the fateful morning of the Archduke's death.

In the prior years to 1914, the major powers of Europe had made preparations for war for years. Germany, dissatisfied with the European balance of power, clashed with the older, dominant powers of Britain and France. Complicated military alliances between nations had already divided much of Europe. Additionally, the European arms race, growing political disputes, and finally, the assassination of the Archduke set off the powder keg that was Europe's geopolitical order. The Central Powers of Germany, Austria-Hungary, and The Ottoman Empire attempted to contest the established power of the Triple Entente— France, Russia, and Great Britain.

What followed was a conflict that fundamentally reshaped the political and territorial landscape of the European continent. On the Eastern front, the Russian Empire had suffered catastrophic military defeats, mounting casualties and growing unrest. The strain of war culminated in the Russian Revolutions of 1917, leading to the Bolshevik's rise to power and the fall of the Tsarist regime. Russia withdrew from the conflict through the Treaty of Brest-Litovsk in March 1918.

Across the Atlantic, the United States entered the war in April of 1917, breaking their preceding commitment to neutrality following the consequences of Germany's unrestricted submarine warfare and the implications of the Zimmerman Telegram. Later on, President Woodrow Wilson's call for national self-determination and new international order greatly challenged and influenced the ambitions of European powers after the war. The Czech, Slovak, and other governments sought increased recognition and legitimacy amidst the shifting political landscape in the wake of the Great War. By the final months of 1918, Germany, Austria-Hungary, and the Russian Empire had all fallen or been transformed, marking the start of a new global order.

Bloc Positions

Security Bloc: Clemenceau, Tarieu, Kramář, Bonar Law

Their ultimate goal is for a weak Germany. They claim that Germany started the war so therefore they must pay and never be able to attack again. They push for big reparations and demilitarization as well as new states in the east. The main concern is security and not sole revenge. Clemenceau saw first hand the invasion of France in 1870 and does not trust any German promises. Tardieu works on the technical details and writes the Rhineland plan. Kramář wants the historic Bohemian borders. He needs France as Czechoslovakia's protector. Additionally, he is also anti-Bolshevik and pro-Russian. Bonar Law supports the act on reparations but less on taking the land. He does not want Britain and France to be too powerful.

League Bloc: Wilson, Borden, Lu Zhengxiang

Built around the League of Nations supporting the ideology that fair peace and collective security prevents another world war. The Bloc pushes the belief that the Covenant must be part of the treaty itself, and every signatory joins automatically. Wilson treats the League Of Nations as his top priority—also having his own 14 points—while Borden supports it provided that Canada gets its own seat. Additionally, Lu Zhengxiang also supports the priority as long as China is treated as an equal amongst the League. This bloc wants reparations to be fair instead of crushing. They suggest for Germany to pay for civilian damage but not for the entire cost of the war.

Moderate Bloc: Lloyd George, Lansing, Borden

Prioritizes stability, balance of power, and to stop Bolshevism from spreading. Argues against putting large numbers of Germans under foreign rule. This bloc suggests that Germany pays, but the total is set by commission depending on what Germany can afford. Lloyd George promised British voters that Germany would pay, and he wants war pensions included to raise Britain's share. However, he does not want to destroy Germany. Lansing holds to armistice terms for civilian damage only. Borden supports whatever restores trade quickly.

Germany: Müller, Bell

Their objective is for a bearable peace and equal standing as the other powers. They believe war is a shared responsibility which emerged out of a system of alliances and an arms race. Blame the fallen imperial government, not the German people. Agree to pay for civilian damage as the armistice promised but only at a fixed total. Germany wants to join the League of Nations either immediately or on a set timeline and as an equal member.

Guiding Questions

1. What were the major consequences of the war on major global powers?
2. How did the collapse of the Russian Empire reshape the European political landscape?
3. What were the motivations of the Allied and Associated powers at the Paris Peace Conference?
4. What role did smaller nations and dominions seek to establish post-war?
5. What were the interests of non-European powers during the negotiations?

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